The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

Donald Trump and his cabinet were safely evacuated from the White House Correspondents' Association dinner after gunshots were fired near the event at the Washington Hilton hotel. The suspect was taken into custody, and the gathering was called off. Mr Trump said a Secret Service officer had been shot, but was protected by a bulletproof vest.

Mr Trump cancelled the trip of **Steve Witkoff** and **Jared Kushner**, two of his envoys, to Pakistan, after **Iranian** officials said that peace talks there would not be face-to-face. Instead Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, held talks with Shehbaz Sharif, Pakistan's prime minister, and Asim Munir, the army chief, in Islamabad. Details were scant, but Mr Araghchi said he had shared Iran's "views and considerations" on ending the war.

Militants in **Mali** launched a series of co-ordinated attacks against towns and cities across the country. The army, which said the situation was under control, did not identify the groups. But a Tuareg-led separatist group claims to have taken control of the northern town of Kidal. The south has long been threatened by jihadists linked to al-Qaeda and Islamic State.

Viktor Orban, the former prime minister of Hungary, said he would not take his seat in parliament when it reconvenes on May 9th. Mr Orban's Fidesz party suffered a crushing defeat at the hands of the country's new leader, Peter Magyar, and his Tisza party earlier this month. "I am now needed not in parliament, but in the reorganisation of the patriotic movement," he said in a Facebook video.

Russia fired 47 missiles and more than 600 drones at **Ukraine** overnight. Ukraine said it had intercepted most of these, though at least seven people were killed, including five in the city of Dnipro. "Most targets are civilian infrastructure in cities," noted the Ukrainian president, Volodymyr Zelensky, on social media. Meanwhile a Ukrainian drone hit an apartment building in the city of Yekaterinburg, nearly 1,600km from the border.

Israel continued its attacks on southern **Lebanon**, killing four people in Nabatieh, even though the ceasefire between the two countries was extended for three weeks by Mr Trump on Thursday. Soldiers also reportedly blew up buildings in the town of Bint Jbeil. Hizbullah, which has fired rockets and drones at Israeli forces, has called the ceasefire "meaningless".

America's **s&p 500** and NASDAQ indexes closed at record highs on Friday, rising by 0.8% and 1.6% respectively. Both were boosted by hopes of talks to end the Iran war, and by a surge in **Intel's** shares. The American chipmaker's stocks rose by 24% on Friday, up to a record high, after it posted strong first-quarter revenues of $13.6bn.

Word of the week: Kriegstüchtig, a term for "war-ready", coined by Boris Pistorius, Germany's defence minister. Read more about how the country's armed forces are getting battle-ready.

Photograph: AP

A pause for now

Donald Trump’s announcement on April 23rd that the ten-day ceasefire between Israel and Hizbullah, an Iran-backed militia in Lebanon, would be extended by three weeks brought only limited relief. The ceasefire paused large-scale air strikes by Israel and missile and drone attacks by Hizbullah on towns in Lebanon and Israel. But both sides have continued to clash in southern Lebanon, where Israel maintains a “security zone”. Many Lebanese civilians are still prevented from returning to their homes and Israeli forces have levelled several villages near the border.

It will be hard to agree security arrangements within Lebanon. The Lebanese government remains powerless to rein in and disarm Hizbullah, and Israel is reluctant to withdraw from the area it has occupied until that happens. Mr Trump, who convened Israeli and Lebanese diplomats for talks, promised to “work with Lebanon in order to help it protect itself from Hizbullah”. But he has yet to come up with a lasting solution.

Photograph: Getty Images

Legacy of a disaster

Forty years ago today, a safety test at the Chernobyl nuclear-power plant in Ukraine went badly wrong. Thirty-one people died in the immediate explosion or from radiation sickness shortly after; the long-run death toll has been estimated at 15,000. The details of the accident and ensuing cover-up revealed the rot of the Soviet Union's bootlicking bureaucracy to its people, and to Mikhail Gorbachev, then the president. The disaster came to be seen as marking the beginning of the union's end.

What is Chernobyl's legacy? Scientists are still working to track the radioactive particles the accident released and to find ways to remediate the environment; this would provide valuable data for future accidents. And the exclusion zone around the plant has become a celebrated experiment in rewilding. Animals have flourished. But in 2022 the pastoral peace was broken: Russians occupied and ransacked the plant on the day they invaded Ukraine.

Photograph: Getty Images

The limits of Takaichi's power

At first glance Japan's prime minister looks like one of her country's most commanding leaders in a generation. In February Takaichi Sanae led her Liberal Democratic Party to its biggest election victory. But six months into office, her grip may be weakening.

Ms Takaichi remains popular among voters. Her party, less so. Its reputation has been tainted by a series of scandals. While the cabinet's approval rating stands at around 65%, the LDP's languishes at around 35%. On April 19th, the party lost seven out of 13 local elections. It faces another batch on Sunday.

The Iran war presents new risks for her. Japan imports over 90% of its crude oil through the Strait of Hormuz. So far, government petrol subsidies have absorbed much of the shock. Yet the subsidy fund, which holds over ¥1trn ($6.3bn), could run dry within two months at current spending rates. If inflation soars, the political cost could be high.

Photograph: AP

Pop go the measles?

For more than six months, South Carolina has been afflicted by one of the worst measles outbreaks in America in recent years. Nearly 1,000 cases have been reported since September. On Sunday the state is expected to declare its end. As with other big outbreaks, cases were clustered in one county with particularly low vaccination rates. These are typically tight-knit religious or immigrant communities with entrenched anti-vaccine attitudes. But not always. In the 2022-24 school years two-thirds of counties in America had measles vaccination rates below the 95% threshold needed to prevent an outbreak. In most counties vaccination rates had dropped since the 2017-2020 school years.

More outbreaks are therefore expected. A single infected person traveling to an undervaccinated county can start one. If new cases linked to an outbreak keep popping up for more than a year, America will lose its measles “elimination” status under the World Health Organisation—an indictment on its public health system.

Photograph: Richard Rodriguez/The Cliburn

A piano superstar's school concert

In 2022, at 18, Lim Yun-chan became the youngest-ever winner of the Van Cliburn piano competition (his performance of Sergei Rachmaninoff's "Piano Concerto No. 3" made the conductor weep). His recording of the "Goldberg Variations", by Johann Sebastian Bach, is currently top of Apple's classical-music chart. Yet Mr Lim is still a student. On Sunday he will play a recital in Boston to get his diploma.

Mr Lim would not look out of place in a boy band, and in his native South Korea his first album (of Chopin's Études) charted just behind the number one, by BoyNextDoor, a K-pop group. He says he lives "only for the sake of music". At the New England Conservatory Mr Lim will be playing for free to 1,000 people. The tickets, naturally, are gone. But another chance to hear him perform comes on July 17th, at the opening concert of the BBC Proms in London, which will be televised.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Amitava Mukerjee, Danville, California, America

Ahmed Alsuwaidi, Dubai, UAE

Claudine Provencher, Cavillon, France

They gave the correct answers of Vitus Bering, Gibraltar, Ferdinand Magellan, Malacca and Hormuz. The theme is famous straits: Bering, Gibraltar, Magellan, Malacca and Hormuz.

The questions were:

Monday: Which Danish explorer spent many years leading expeditions for the Russian navy in the 18th century?

Tuesday: Which port and naval base was ceded to Britain by Spain in the 1713 Treaty of Utrecht?

Wednesday: Which Portuguese explorer was the first European to cross the Pacific?

Thursday: Which Malaysian state is bordered by Negeri Sembilan to the north and Johor to the east?

Friday: Which medieval kingdom in the Persian gulf was ruled by descendants of Muhammad Diramku?

A nation of sheep will beget a government of wolves.

Edward Murrow